Plan 5 · Uttarakhand: Rishikesh to Chandrashila & Auli

Ganga aarti and cafés in Rishikesh, Devprayag confluence, Deoria Tal, a snow trek to Tungnath & Chandrashila (4,000 m), Auli's slopes and Gorson Bugyal, Haridwar. 24 Dec 2026 – 3 Jan 2027

At a glance

Route	Hyderabad → Delhi → Rishikesh 2N → Devprayag → Sari 1N → Chopta/Duggalbitta 2N → Joshimath 2N (Auli) → Haridwar → Delhi → Hyderabad
Snow chances	High: Tungnath–Chandrashila, Auli, Gorson. Medium: Deoria Tal, Chopta. None: Rishikesh, Haridwar
Crowd level	Medium in Rishikesh. Low–medium at Chopta (weekend trekkers). Low at Auli (ropeway shut) and Deoria Tal
Difficulty	Moderate. Chandrashila in snow is a 6–8 h day (about 10 km round trip from Chopta) and needs microspikes and a guide
Temperatures	Rishikesh 7–20 °C · Sari 0–12 °C · Chopta −8 to 3 °C · Auli/Joshimath −6 to 8 °C
Budget per person (6 people)	**≈ ₹20.7k shoestring** (SL, ordinary buses) · **≈ ₹29.1k recommended** (3A, Volvo, better stays). One Innova for all 6 is cheaper per head than buses + shared jeeps once you add the waiting

Things that changed recently

Joshimath–Auli ropeway is shut (since Jan 2023 land subsidence). A new line is only at project-report stage. Auli is reached by road (16 km from Joshimath; local jeeps run). Don't pay any 'ropeway ticket' website.

Tungnath temple doors are closed in winter (the deity moves to Makkumath). The trek is open and snow-covered. In winter, stays beyond Duggalbitta are closed and there is no electricity at the higher points.

Rishikesh's old **Laxman Jhula** bridge has been closed for safety since 2022; use Ram Jhula / Janki Setu.

Getting there and back

Hyderabad → Delhi on 24 Dec: board in Hyderabad, Kazipet, Warangal or Vijayawada

Train	Where you board (time)	Reaches Delhi	Runs	Fare / person (SL · 3A)	Use it for
12723 Telangana SF Exp	**Hyderabad Deccan 06:00** · Secunderabad 06:20/06:25 · Kazipet 08:03/08:05	New Delhi ~07:40–08:00 (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Default.** Cheapest, boards in the city. Delhi day + night train/bus onward
12621 Tamil Nadu SF Exp	Vijayawada 03:50–04:05 · Warangal 06:50/06:52 · **Kazipet 06:55**	New Delhi **06:30** (25 Dec)	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950 (from Kazipet)	**Fast option.** Catches the 07:40 Kalka Shatabdi → Shimla same evening
22691 Bengaluru–Nizamuddin Rajdhani	Secunderabad 07:00/07:10 · Kazipet ~08:50	H. Nizamuddin 05:30	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100 (meals incl.)	Fast and comfortable but ~2× the 3A fare
12625 Kerala SF Exp	Vijayawada ~10:10–10:55 · Warangal ~13:30 · **Kazipet 13:45**	New Delhi 13:30	Daily	≈ ₹750 · ≈ ₹1,950	Backup if 12723 is full (leave Hyderabad by 09:30 by bus)
12285 Secunderabad–Nizamuddin Duronto	Secunderabad 12:50	H. Nizamuddin ~10:40	Sun & Thu	3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Runs on 24 Dec (Thu)

Getting to Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada with 6 people: Kazipet and Warangal are ~140 km (2.5–3 h). TGSRTC buses run through the night from JBS/Uppal to Hanamkonda (≈ ₹200–300), or an Innova one-way ≈ ₹4,000–5,000 (≈ ₹750 pp). Vijayawada is ~275 km (5–6 h). Only worth it if Hyderabad quota is full, because you'd need an overnight bus on 23 Dec.

12723 halts in order (check availability to each): Hyderabad Deccan → Secunderabad → Kazipet → Ramagundam → Mancherial → Sirpur Kagaznagar → Balharshah → Chandrapur → Sevagram → Nagpur → Itarsi → Bhopal → Jhansi → Gwalior → Agra Cantt → New Delhi (~18 halts, ~1,680 km). Confirmed: HYB 06:00, SC 06:20/06:25, Kazipet 08:03/08:05, Ramagundam 09:28/09:30.

Waitlisted? Check every station and halt this way

1. Direct pairs. On IRCTC / ConfirmTkt / ixigo, search 24 Dec: HYB→NDLS, SC→NDLS, SC→NZM, **KZJ→NDLS, WL→NDLS, BZA→NDLS** (Kazipet, Warangal and Vijayawada have their own quotas). Note AVAILABLE / RAC / WL for every train above.

2. Every halt. If HYB→Delhi is WL, search the same train from HYB to each later halt (Agra Cantt, Gwalior, Jhansi, Bhopal, Itarsi, Nagpur). A shorter ticket can be AVAILABLE when the full one is WL. Ride to Agra, then any Agra→Delhi train or bus (2–3.5 h).

3. Book from the origin. For trains starting elsewhere (22691 from Bengaluru, 12621 from Chennai, 12625 from Thiruvananthapuram), search origin→Delhi and set **Boarding Point** = Secunderabad / Kazipet / Warangal / Vijayawada. You pay the full-route fare but get the origin's quota.

4. Split it. HYB→Nagpur + Nagpur→Delhi (30+ trains a day). Keep 2–3 h between them.

5. Tatkal on 23 Dec (AC 10:00, SL 11:00), 2 PNRs of 3 people each. Premium Tatkal costs more but confirms more often.

6. Tick Vikalp + auto-upgrade and only hold WL if it is under ~WL 20 (3A) / WL 40 (SL) this far out.

6 people = 1 PNR in general quota (max 6 passengers per ticket), but **Tatkal allows only 4 per PNR**, so Tatkal needs 2 bookings from 2 Aadhaar-verified IRCTC accounts at the same minute. Senior citizens get lower berths only in general quota.

Back to Hyderabad by 3 Jan

Train	Leaves	Reaches Hyderabad	Runs	Fare (SL · 3A)	Fits 'home by 3 Jan'?
12724 Telangana SF Exp	New Delhi **16:00**	Hyderabad Deccan ~17:10 next day	Daily	≈ ₹800 · ≈ ₹2,100	**Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan evening**
22692 Nizamuddin–Bengaluru Rajdhani	H. Nizamuddin late evening (≈ 20:30–21:00, verify)	Secunderabad 17:10 arr next day	Daily	3A ≈ ₹3,300–4,100	Leave 2 Jan → home 3 Jan
12286 Nizamuddin–Secunderabad Duronto	H. Nizamuddin 15:55	Secunderabad ~14:35 next day	Mon & Fri	3A ≈ ₹3,000–3,700	Leave 1 Jan (Fri) → home 2 Jan
12722 Dakshin SF Exp	H. Nizamuddin 22:50	Hyderabad Deccan ~03:50 on day 3	Daily	≈ ₹780 · ≈ ₹2,100	Leave 1 Jan night → home 3 Jan 04:00

Delhi ↔ Rishikesh / Haridwar and the hill loop

Leg	Option	Time	Approx cost
Delhi → Rishikesh (25 Dec)	UTC / private Volvo from ISBT Kashmere Gate (frequent through the day)	6–7 h	₹500–900 pp
Alt: Delhi → Dehradun / Haridwar by train	Delhi–Dehradun Vande Bharat / Shatabdi / Jan Shatabdi (VB CC ≈ ₹1,065 at launch; the morning Shatabdi leaves too early for a 07:40 arrival). Check IRCTC for 25 Dec afternoon chair cars	4.5–5 h	₹600–1,100
Rishikesh → Ukhimath (budget)	GMOU / Uttarakhand Roadways bus from Rishikesh bus stand ~05:00–07:00, then shared jeep to Sari	8–9 h	≈ ₹400–500
Hill loop by cab (recommended)	Dzire/Ertiga/Bolero with driver 27 Dec – 1 Jan: Rishikesh → Sari → Chopta → Joshimath/Auli → Haridwar	6 days	Innova Crysta ≈ ₹4,500–5,000/day + ₹400 driver night + tolls ≈ ₹32–33k (÷ 6 ≈ ₹5,300)
Haridwar → Delhi (1 Jan night)	Overnight train (e.g. Mussoorie Exp-type departures ~22:00–23:30; verify) or UTC Volvo	6–7 h	SL ≈ ₹250 · 3A ≈ ₹700 · Volvo ≈ ₹800

Flights from Hyderabad (to save 1–2 days)

Route (non-stop)	Airlines	Flight time	Typical Dec-Jan one-way fare*	Useful for
Hyderabad ↔ Delhi	IndiGo, Air India, Akasa, SpiceJet	~2 h 10 m	₹6,000–9,000 (peak ₹10–12k)	Plans 1, 2, 3, 5, 6, 7
Hyderabad ↔ Dehradun	IndiGo (~10 flights/week)	~2 h 25 m	₹5,000–9,000	Plan 5

*Snapshot ranges from MakeMyTrip, Goibibo, Skyscanner, HappyFares, ixigo (Nov 2026), not live quotes. IndiGo: 7 kg cabin + 15 kg check-in on most fares. Fares climb weekly from here for 24 Dec and 2 Jan.

Faster by air

Fly Hyderabad → Dehradun (IndiGo direct, about 10 flights a week; ₹5–9k) on 24 Dec and taxi to Rishikesh (~1 h). You gain a full day: add Kunjapuri sunrise + Neer Garh falls, or a night in Khirsu/Lansdowne (offbeat) on the way back.

Getting around as 6

Option for 6 people	Seats / luggage	Typical hill rate (2025-26)	Per person per day (÷6)	When to choose
Innova Crysta with driver	6–7 + roof carrier	₹4,000–5,500/day (min ~250 km) or ₹16–18/km, + tolls, parking, ₹300–500 driver night	≈ ₹750–1,000	Default for 6 with soft bags
Tempo Traveller 12-seater	Lots of room	₹4,500–7,500/day or ₹18–22/km	≈ ₹850–1,250	Heavy luggage; not allowed on some narrow roads / union areas
2 × Dzire / Etios	4 + 4	₹2,800–3,500/day each	≈ ₹950–1,150	Only if no SUV is available
Local taxi unions (Manali, Pahalgam, Gangtok, Joshimath)	Innova / Tavera / Sumo	Fixed rate cards per circuit	Varies	Mandatory for some circuits (Solang–Sissu, Aru–Betaab, Tsomgo)
Government bus (HRTC / JKSRTC / UTC)	Seats	₹1.5–3 per km	Cheapest	Long point-to-point legs (Shimla→Manali, Delhi→hills)

Day-by-day itinerary

Day 1 · Thu 24 Dec · Hyderabad → on the train

• **06:00 12723 Telangana Express** (or 07:10 22691 Rajdhani from Secunderabad).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 food

Day 2 · Fri 25 Dec · Delhi → Rishikesh · Ganga aarti

• Metro to Kashmere Gate → Volvo to Rishikesh (~09:00 → ~16:00).

• Evening **Triveni Ghat** or **Parmarth Niketan** Ganga aarti (around sunset, ~17:30 in winter).

Stay: Airbnb Tapovan (2–3 BR apartment) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹450–800 bus + ₹600 food

Day 3 · Sat 26 Dec · Rishikesh by scooty

• Rent a scooty (₹500–700 + ₹1,500 deposit). **Beatles Ashram (Chaurasi Kutia)**, Ram Jhula, Janki Setu, Parmarth & Swarg Ashram ghats.

• **Neer Garh waterfall** (short trek, offbeat-ish). Optional river rafting from Shivpuri (16 km, ₹600–1,000). The water is cold but rafts do run.

• Cafés on the Tapovan side, sunset at Beatles Ashram.

Stay: Rishikesh | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 scooty share (3 scooties) + ₹100 fuel + ₹700 rafting (optional) + ₹600 food

Day 4 · Sun 27 Dec · Rishikesh → Devprayag → Rudraprayag → Sari

• Leave 06:30. **Devprayag**: Alaknanda meets Bhagirathi and the Ganga begins. Short walk down to the sangam.

• Optional quick stops: Dhari Devi temple (Srinagar Garhwal), Rudraprayag confluence. Then Ukhimath → **Sari village** (~2,000 m), 7–8 h total.

Stay: Sari homestay, 3 rooms (₹1,000–1,500 per room, meals ₹250–350; not on Airbnb) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹880 Innova share + ₹600 food

Day 5 · Mon 28 Dec · Deoria Tal → Chopta / Duggalbitta

• Early trek to **Deoria Tal** (2.5–3 km, 1.5 h up): mirror view of Chaukhamba. Ice on the edges in late Dec. Small entry/eco fee.

• Descend, drive to **Duggalbitta / Chopta** (25 km). Rent microspikes + gaiters for tomorrow (₹150–250/day).

• Book your Tungnath guide tonight (₹1,500–2,000 per group).

Stay: Duggalbitta camp / lodge with meals (₹1,000–1,500 pp) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹880 Innova share + ₹250 rentals

Day 6 · Tue 29 Dec · Tungnath (3,680 m) + Chandrashila summit (4,000 m) in snow

• Start 06:30 from Chopta. 3.5 km to **Tungnath** (world's highest Shiva temple; doors shut in winter) + 1.5 km steep to **Chandrashila**: 360° view of Nanda Devi, Trishul, Chaukhamba, Kedar peaks.

• Turn-around time 12:30 whatever happens. Back by 15:00–16:00. Hot Maggi + chai at Chopta.

Stay: Duggalbitta (or drop to Ukhimath) | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 guide share + ₹1,200 camp + ₹300 food

Day 7 · Wed 30 Dec · Ukhimath → the five prayags → Joshimath

• **Omkareshwar temple, Ukhimath**, the winter seat of Kedarnath (puja happens here in winter).

• Drive via Rudraprayag → Karnaprayag → Nandprayag → Chamoli → **Joshimath** (6–7 h). If the Chopta–Mandal–Gopeshwar road is open, it's shorter.

• Evening: Narsingh temple (winter seat of Badrinath).

Stay: Airbnb Joshimath / near Auli | **Day spend (per person):** ₹880 Innova share + ₹700 food

Day 8 · Thu 31 Dec · Auli snow day + Gorson Bugyal · quiet NYE

- Drive up to **Auli** (16 km). Snow slopes, the GMVN ski area (beginner lessons + gear ≈ ₹1,500–2,500/day in season), Auli artificial lake.
- **Gorson Bugyal** (offbeat): 3 km snow walk through oak and rhododendron to a meadow facing Nanda Devi.
- NYE in Joshimath/Auli is low-key: bonfire and dinner at the hotel.

Stay: Airbnb Joshimath | **Day spend (per person):** ₹880 Innova share + ₹300–800 snow activities + ₹800 food

Day 9 · Fri 1 Jan · Joshimath → Haridwar (Har Ki Pauri) → night to Delhi

- Leave by 07:00 (~255 km, 8–9 h). If you reach by 17:30, catch the **Har Ki Pauri** evening aarti in Haridwar.
- Overnight train / Volvo Haridwar → Delhi.

Stay: Train / bus | **Day spend (per person):** ₹880 Innova share + ₹250–700 train/bus + ₹600 food

Day 10 · Sat 2 Jan · Delhi → Hyderabad

- **16:00 12724 Telangana Express** (or 22692 Rajdhani late evening).

Stay: Train | **Day spend (per person):** ₹300 Delhi + ₹600 food

Day 11 · Sun 3 Jan · Home

- Hyderabad ~17:10.

Where you sleep: Airbnb picks for 6 (best-rated and budget)

Nights	Area	Best-rated pick	Budget pick	Est. Dec price, 6 people / night	≈ per person / night
2 (25–26 Dec)	Rishikesh (Tapovan)	**White House Rishikesh Tapovan**: 4.73★ (81), sleeps 6 · **Apartment in Tapovan** 2 BR, 6 guests, 4.79★ (29)	**Spacious 3 BHK Ganga View Apartment, Tapovan** (sleeps 7–8 with extra beds) · or 2 private rooms in hostels	₹4,000–7,000	₹650–1,150
1 (27 Dec)	Sari village	Not on Airbnb: family homestays (book by phone / via your driver)	3 rooms × ₹1,000–1,500, dinner ₹250–350	₹3,000–4,500	₹500–750
2 (28–29 Dec)	Duggalbitta / Chopta	Winter camps & lodges at Duggalbitta (the only ones open)	Priced per person ₹1,000–1,500 with meals	₹6,000–9,000	₹1,000–1,500
2 (30–31 Dec)	Joshimath / Auli	**Vaadi, entire villa near Auli** (2 BR, 5 guests, 5.0★) + its **Forest View Cabin** (5.0★, 14) for 6	**Home stay in Joshimath** (4.85★, 20 reviews) · GMVN Auli dorms	₹3,500–6,000	₹600–1,000

Listing names, ratings and review counts come from Airbnb search results in Nov 2026. Airbnb blocks automated price checks, so the 'Dec price for 6' column is an **estimate** for an entire 3-bedroom place over the holiday week. Check the live total for your dates.

How to pick the best-rated vs the cheapest on Airbnb

Filters: Guests = 6 · Type of place = **Entire home** · Bedrooms ≥ 3 (or 2 + sofa-beds) · tick **Guest favourite** · toggle **'Display total before taxes'** so the price includes cleaning and service fees.

Best-rated vs cheapest: sort by price after setting the filters, then pick the cheapest listing with ≥ 4.7★ and ≥ 20 reviews. A 5.0★ with 3 reviews is not more reliable than a 4.8★ with 150.

Winter questions to message the host before booking: room heaters (some charge ₹300–500/night per heater), geyser/hot water, power backup, whether a car reaches the door (Old Manali, Vashisht, Jibhi and McLeodganj often have steep stairs), and snow-time access.

NYE rules: many hosts set a 2–3 night minimum for 30 Dec–1 Jan. Book those nights first with flexible or moderate cancellation.

Where Airbnb is thin (Zuluk, Aritar, Rinchenpong, Sari/Chopta, Sangla/Kalpa, Bandipur, Spiti), book homestays by phone or on Booking.com / MakeMyTrip. Usually 3 rooms × ₹1,500–3,000 with meals.

Places: main vs offbeat

Place	Type	Why
Rishikesh (ghats, aarti, Beatles Ashram)	Main	Yoga capital, Ganga, cafés
Neer Garh falls, Kunjapuri (sunrise)	Offbeat	Short hikes near Rishikesh
Devprayag sangam	Semi-offbeat	Where the Ganga officially begins
Sari village + Deoria Tal	Offbeat	Village homestay, mirror lake
Chopta, Tungnath, Chandrashila	Main (trekkers)	Snow trek to 4,000 m with a giant Himalayan panorama
Omkareshwar (Ukhimath), Narsingh (Joshimath)	Offbeat	Winter seats of Kedarnath and Badrinath
Auli slopes	Main	India's best-known ski slopes
Gorson Bugyal	Offbeat	Snow meadow above Auli, few people
Haridwar Har Ki Pauri	Main	Evening aarti

Variants if you prefer

Variant	What changes	Cost impact
Kedarkantha winter trek (classic Dec snow trek, summit ~3,800 m)	Fly HYD → Dehradun 24 Dec; operator pickup Dehradun 25/26 Dec → Sankri → 6D/5N trek → Dehradun 31 Dec/1 Jan; train/flight back	Trek ₹6,000–11,000 (Sankri–Sankri to Dehradun–Dehradun; +5% GST; forest fee ₹150–300). Total ≈ ₹28–34k with one flight
Kumaon: Nainital (main) + Mukteshwar + Binsar / Munsiyari (offbeat)	Delhi → Kathgodam train; Munsiyari is 10–11 h further and gets snow from late Dec	Similar to this plan; more driving
Easy hills: Mussoorie–Landour–Dhanaulti–Kanatal	Base in Mussoorie/Landour, day trips; no trekking	≈ ₹24–28k

Bike / scooty rentals

Where	Rates	Notes
Rishikesh (Tapovan, Laxman Jhula road)	Scooty ₹500–700 · RE ₹1,750–1,900	Deposit ≈ ₹1,500. Many shops restrict use to Rishikesh limits
Dehradun (app rentals)	RE / bikes ₹1,200–2,000	Outstation allowed by some, but snow and ice above 2,500 m (Chopta, Auli) make it unsafe in late Dec
Joshimath	Few shops; ₹800–1,500	Use local jeeps for Auli after snowfall

Winter gear: what to buy, what to rent, and where

Gear budget: if you own nothing warm, expect ₹4,000–6,500 one-time purchase (thermals, fleece, gloves, cap, socks, sunglasses) + ₹800–1,500 rentals on the trip. Plan budgets include only the rentals. Six people can share: buy 2 pairs of microspikes and 1 first-aid kit for the group instead of 6.

Item	Need	Buy (Decathlon Hyderabad / local)	Rent (where & rate)	Advice
Thermal inner set (top + bottom) ×2	Must	₹800–1,200 per set (local ₹400–600)	Not rented (hygiene)	Buy. Merino/poly, not cotton
Fleece / sweater (mid layer)	Must	₹600–1,200	—	Buy
Padded / down jacket (−5 to −10 °C)	Must	₹2,500–5,000	Indiahikes rentals ₹55–80/day (ships to you); trek operators ₹100/day; Manali / Gulmarg shops ₹150–300/day	Rent if you won't reuse it: 10 days ≈ ₹600–1,000
One-piece snow suit	Snow points	—	Solang/Palchan, Kufri, Gulmarg, Tsomgo ₹250–500/day (often with gumboots)	Rent on the spot
Gumboots / snow boots	Snow points	—	₹100–200/day (bundled with suit at Solang ₹400–500)	Rent on the spot
Waterproof trekking shoes	Treks	₹2,000–3,500 (Decathlon MH100/MH500)	Trek operators ₹100–150/day	Buy if you'll trek again
Waterproof gloves + woollen inners	Must	₹300–900 + ₹150	—	Buy
Woollen cap / balaclava / neck gaiter	Must	₹200–400 each	—	Buy
Woollen socks (4 pairs)	Must	₹400–600	—	Buy
UV400 sunglasses	Snow	₹300–800	—	Prevents snow-blindness
Microspikes + gaiters	Treks / icy walks	₹1,200–1,800	Chopta/Sari/Sankri/Dharamkot ₹150–250/day; gaiters ₹100/day	Rent

Rental points on this route

Point	What you can rent	Rate
Sari / Chopta / Duggalbitta shops	Microspikes, gaiters, trekking poles, gumboots, jackets	₹100–250 per item/day
Auli (GMVN & private ski shops)	Skis, boots, poles, suits; lessons	₹1,500–2,500 per day with instruction
Decathlon Dehradun (buy)	Thermals, fleeces, trek shoes, spikes	Cheaper than buying in the hills
Trek operators (Indiahikes, Trek The Himalayas rentals)	Padded jacket, shoes	₹55–150/day

Budget per person (6 people sharing)

Item (per person, 6 sharing)	Shoestring	Recommended	Notes
Train Hyderabad → Delhi (12723)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Delhi → Rishikesh bus	₹450	₹800	UTC ordinary vs Volvo
Rishikesh: 3 scooties + fuel	₹300	₹350	
Rafting (optional)	₹0	₹700	
One Innova, 27 Dec – 1 Jan (6 days + driver nights + tolls)	₹5,300	₹5,500	≈ ₹32–33k ÷ 6
Guide for Tungnath–Chandrashila	₹300	₹300	≈ ₹1,800 ÷ 6
Microspikes, gaiters	₹300	₹300	
Auli snow activities	₹300	₹800	
Haridwar → Delhi overnight	₹250	₹250	SL train (3A ≈ ₹700)
Delhi half-day on 2 Jan	₹300	₹400	
Train Delhi → Hyderabad (12724)	₹800	₹2,100	SL vs 3A
Stays: 2N Rishikesh Airbnb, 1N Sari, 2N Duggalbitta camp, 2N Joshimath Airbnb	₹5,100	₹8,000	÷ 6 (camps priced per person with meals)
Food	₹4,800	₹5,300	
Metro, autos, misc	₹300	₹400	
Gear rentals	₹600	₹800	
Buffer	₹800	₹1,000	
TOTAL per person	**₹20,700**	**₹29,100**	**Fits ₹25–30k comfortably. The cheapest plan once 6 people share one Innova.**

Bookings to do now

- Return train 2 Jan + Haridwar→Delhi on 1 Jan night, then the onward train for 24 Dec.
- Cab for 27 Dec – 1 Jan from a Rishikesh agency (fix the per-day rate, night halts, and who pays tolls/parking in writing).
- Duggalbitta camp (2 nights) and Joshimath hotel (30–31 Dec). Rishikesh hostels can be booked a week before.

Plan B

- Heavy snow closes Chopta road: stay at Ukhimath/Sari and do Deoria Tal + Kartik Swami (offbeat summit temple, 3 km trek) instead.
- Joshimath–Auli road blocked: Gorson/Auli on foot only if police allow; else go to Khirsu or Lansdowne on the way back.
- Fog delays the train into Delhi on 25 Dec: take a later Volvo, or the overnight Volvo and sleep on the bus.

Carry list

- Original photo ID (Aadhaar/DL) + 2 photocopies + **4 passport photos** each (Sikkim/Bhutan permits, J&K checks). **Nepal: passport or voter ID** (Aadhaar is generally not accepted).
- Power bank (cold halves battery life), offline maps, ₹5–8k cash each (ATMs fail in snow areas).
- Group med kit: paracetamol, ORS, cold/cough tablets, band-aids, Vaseline, motion-sickness tablets (hill roads). Diamox only on a doctor's advice.
- Thermos for hot water, quick-dry towel, plastic bags for wet gear, a 3-pin multi-plug for the Airbnb (one socket per room is common).

- Prepaid SIMs from outside J&K don't work in Kashmir. Carry at least 2 postpaid connections in the group (Plan 3).

Safety & buffers

- Roads and snow change by the hour. Check state police traffic updates and ask your host each evening. Emergency: **112**. HP disaster helpline: **1077**.
- No two-wheelers on fresh snow or black ice. Taxis with chains are safer after snowfall.
- Book 30 Dec–1 Jan stays first (NYE rates 2–3×). Prefer flexible cancellation.
- Start the last long leg (hills → Delhi/railhead) by 1 Jan. NYE traffic and snow delay buses 3–8 h.
- Chandrashila: don't go without a guide after fresh snow (hidden trail edges). Start early, turn back by 12:30, carry a head-torch.

Sources checked

Reddit and direct page fetches (Airbnb, IRCTC, erail, ConfirmTkt) were blocked from this environment, so everything here comes from web-search results: Airbnb listing snippets, rail timetable aggregators, Team-BHP, Tripoto, travel blogs and local news. Live seat availability and live prices could not be checked; use the checklists above to verify.

— Auli ropeway closure since 2023 and DPR status: happyfares Auli guide (Oct 2026), discoverwithdheeraj, Pioneer Edge, The Week
— Chopta–Tungnath–Chandrashila winter conditions & package costs: Indiahikes Chopta guide, Trek The Himalayas, himalayashelter, trekupindia, tourmyholiday
— Kedarkantha 2026 prices: Adventure Club Pune, Trek The Himalayas, Trek Hievers, Himalayan Hikers, TrekGo cost guide (Aug 2026), discoverwithdheeraj
— Uttarakhand offbeat winter (Munsiyari, Chakrata, Khirsu, Harsil, Kanatal): explurger, Outlook Traveller, StayVista, India TV (Dec 2025)
— Delhi–Dehradun Vande Bharat fares/timings: WION, Zee News, NativePlanet (launch 2023; verify current)
— Rishikesh rentals: Thrillophilia, Onn Bikes tariff; Dehradun/hill rentals: bikewalebhaiya
— HYD–DED flights: flightconnections, Skyscanner, HappyFares, tourmyindia (IndiGo direct)